3.3 Consequences of the War

Restless Americans dreaming of new opportunities set westward expansion in motion. Then the United States seized vast new western territories in a war with Mexico. Some Americans' dream of manifest destiny seemed to be coming true.

MAIN IDEA After a series of treaties, land purchases, and international agreements, the United States stretched from the Atlantic to the Pacific.

OCEAN TO OCEAN

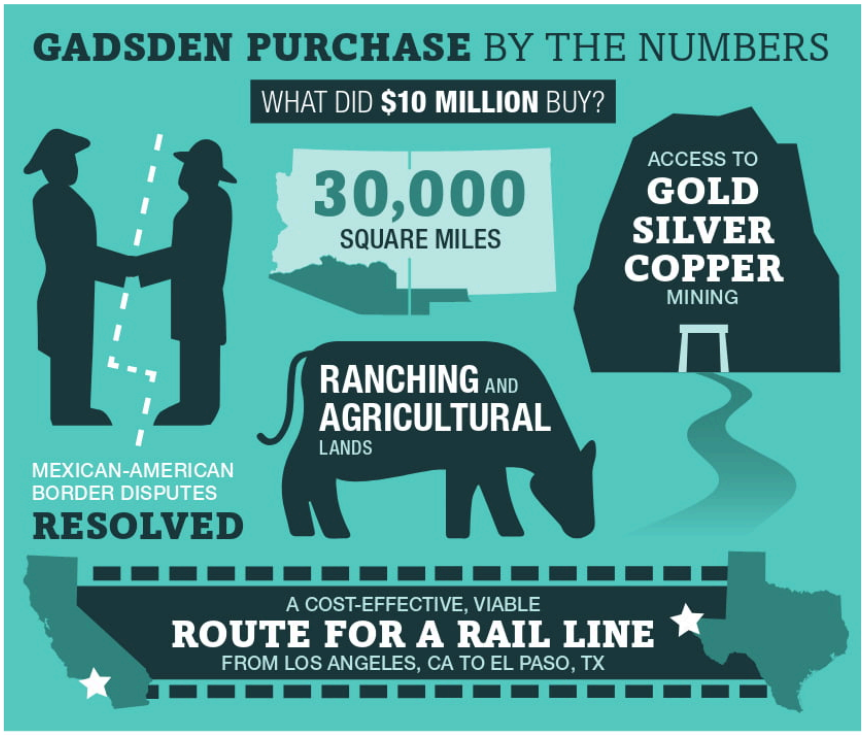
With the fall of Mexico City, the United States had won the Mexican-American War. The war officially ended in February 1848, when the United States and Mexico signed the **Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo**. The treaty set the Rio Grande as the border between Texas and Mexico and, in exchange for $15 million, Mexico gave up its northernmost territories. These territories included present-day California, Nevada, and Utah, as well as parts of Arizona, New Mexico, Colorado, and Wyoming. Upon the signing of the treaty, tens of thousands of people who had previously considered themselves Mexicans became Americans overnight.

The United States now stretched from the Atlantic Ocean to the Pacific Ocean. But the victory over Mexico aggravated an already looming problem.



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The addition of so much land only worsened conflicts over slavery. The new territories were not part of the Missouri Compromise. What would happen when they gained enough population to become states? Would these states be free states or slave states?



While the Mexican-American War was still in progress, Representative David Wilmot of Pennsylvania introduced a plan called the **Wilmot Proviso**. A **proviso** is a condition attached to a legal document or legislation. The Wilmot Proviso was originally attached to a bill meant to pay for a portion of the Mexican-American War. It called for slavery to be barred from any territory gained from the Mexican-American War. President Polk and other pro-slavery southerners opposed this plan and offered an alternate proposal: to extend the Missouri Compromise line westward. Slavery would be allowed in territories south of the line and prohibited in territories north of it. The Wilmot Proviso passed several times in the House of Representatives but not in the Senate. Without passage of this proviso into law, the subject of slavery in new states remained a major concern.

NEW BORDERS, NORTH AND SOUTH

At the same time the United States was adding land in the West, it began to clash with Great Britain over land in the Northwest: the Oregon Territory. Fortunately, diplomacy, not war, ended this conflict. Lawmakers from the United States and Britain agreed to a compromise, setting the northern border of the United States at the 49th **parallel**, or line of latitude, located 49° N of the equator.

Another puzzle piece of American territory fell into place in 1853, when Mexico sold the United States a sliver of land located along the southern edges of present-day Arizona and New Mexico. This $10 million deal, called the **Gadsden Purchase**, granted the United States land it needed to complete a southern transcontinental railroad. It also completed the borders of the **contiguous**, or connected, United States.

The Mexican-American War led to a monumental increase in the size of the United States and an important addition to American culture and identity. For generations, Mexican Americans have contributed to and shaped the United States, and their culture has particularly deep roots in the region that once belonged to Spain and Mexico. Place names throughout the Southwest reflect their Hispanic heritage, and Mexican cultural traditions shape life and identity in many southwestern communities. Spanish and Mexican people and their descendants also played a large role in California's story as it moved toward statehood.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What events finalized the borders of the western United States?
2. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** Why did each acquisition of new territory renew conflicts over slavery?
3. **INTERPRET MAPS** Locate present-day state borders on the map. How many states or parts of states were added to U.S. territory between 1803 and 1853?

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